

ers, sinks, dishwashers, and clothes washers. Prices for drain-water heat-recovery systems range from \$550 to \$850 (and you'll need a qualified plumbing and heating contractor to install the system). It can take 2.5 to 7 years to recover that cost in savings, depending on how often the system is used.

7. Buy a more efficient one

If your water heater is old, it might be good to look into getting a new one. New water heaters today are considerably more energy-efficient than those of 20 years ago. In addition, Energy Star models can be up to 50% more efficient than standard models. Look for one with heat traps, which prevents convective heat losses through the inlet and outlet pipes. Find the best type of water heater for your home and look for rebates and incentives at energystar.gov for energy-efficient appliances and equipment.

— Lynn Truong



6 Clever Green Gifting Strategies

Need to find a gift that's affordable, desirable, and green? Here are six of them.

1. Activities

This gift idea has the added benefit of including things the recipient might not be able to carve out cash for currently, but would love to be able to do. When we are really pinching pennies, fun is one of the first things to be cut from the budget. Get your friend national or state park passes to go hiking or take the kids and dogs on a picnic, season theater tickets, restaurant certificates, massage appointments—get the idea?

2. Seeds

This was what we gave out as wedding favors. Rather than going with the little plastic trinkets that do nothing but get pitched in the trash, we went with seed packets printed with a wedding wish and decorated tastefully on the front. They were for a perennial